



HISTORIC EDEN CEMETERY · PROJECT HANDOFF

Eden Deliverables

Brand Narrative, Tour & Technical Architecture

PREPARED FOR HISTORIC EDEN CEMETERY BY 1838 BLACK METROPOLIS · OCTOBER
2026

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SECTION 1

Brand Narrative & Awareness Strategy

The core story of a Black institution built to preserve dignity, memory, and permanence.

Brand Narrative and Awareness Strategy

Brand narrative, positioning, and the core story of a Black institution built to preserve dignity, memory, and permanence.

PREPARED FOR 1838 BLACK METROPOLIS × HISTORIC EDEN CEMETERY · 2026

NORTH STAR

Eden is the full-circle answer to a long history of Black dispossession: a place created so that dignity would not end at death, and where the lives of Black Philadelphia could remain visible, protected, and connected to future generations.

CORE POSITIONING

Historic Eden Cemetery is not simply a burial ground. It is a sacred Black cultural landscape created through collective agency at a moment when racism, segregation, urban expansion, condemnation, and the closure of earlier Black cemeteries threatened both the dignity of the dead and the continuity of Black memory. Eden became the community's answer: Black-controlled ground where people could be buried with respect and where their histories would endure.

Today, Eden holds more than 93,000 lives across 17,000 lots on 53 acres — including abolitionists, educators, ministers, veterans, artists, physicians, architects, civic leaders, families, and everyday Black citizens whose collective stories helped build Black Philadelphia and shape the nation. Eden's cultural importance is therefore not based only on who is famous enough to be called "notable." Its power lies in the extraordinary and the everyday resting together, preserving the full social fabric of Black life.

That makes Eden a "full-circle" institution: Black communities created sacred space when dominant systems denied them dignity; Eden later received people displaced from Black burial grounds that had been erased or forced to close; and today the cemetery can return those lives to public memory through preservation, education, research, visitation, and community stewardship.

Brand Promise

Eden protects more than graves. It protects the dignity, evidence, memory, and continuity of Black life — so that what was pushed out of sight is never pushed out of history.

Primary Brand Idea

From displacement to dignity. From burial to memory. From the ancestors to us.

Strategic Objective

Drive awareness of Eden as an essential Black cultural institution and **convert** that awareness into visitation, partnership, sponsorship, preservation support, and long-term financial sustainability.

VOICE, NARRATIVE ARCHITECTURE & HEADLINES

How Eden Should Sound

A voice grounded in reverence, agency, intimacy, and historical consequence — never morbidity, nostalgia, or generic heritage tourism.

Brand Voice

- 01 Sacred, not solemn-only:** Death is present, but the language should center on continuity, dignity, reverence, kinship, and ancestral relationship rather than fear or morbidity.
Focus on the spiritual interconnectedness of Blackness.
- 02 Historically grounded:** Use evidence, names, places, dates, and institutional history to make Eden's significance undeniable.
- 03 Black-centered and self-determined:** Eden should be described as something Black Philadelphians built, protected, and sustained — not merely as a site where Black people happen to be buried.

- 04 Accessible, not flattened:** The story should be clear enough for families, students, tourists, and media while retaining intellectual depth.
A concise elevator pitch — see Appendix A.
- 05 Present-tense:** Eden is not a relic. It is an active cemetery, research resource, gathering place, classroom, sacred landscape, and living institution.

Narrative Pillars

- 01 Dignity as Resistance** — Eden was founded so death would not become another site of racial dispossession. The very existence of Black-controlled burial space is an act of agency.
- 02 The Collection Cemetery** — When earlier Black burial grounds were forced to close, Eden became a place of return, preservation, and continuity. It gathered what the city displaced.
- 03 Black Philadelphia in Full** — Eden holds the famous and the familiar. Its 93,000 stories reveal Black life across class, profession, faith, family, politics, art, science, military service, and everyday community.
- 04 Memory Across Generations** — Eden is where descendants can find evidence of themselves. The cemetery makes ancestry tangible and gives younger generations a place to encounter the people who came before them.
- 05 A Living Future** — Preservation is not backward-looking. Protecting Eden enables future education, research, public history, family connection, and community ownership.

COMMUNITY-ROOTED HEADLINE TERRITORY

That's ours

Eden held them.

From the ordinary to the extraordinary

Where Black memory lives

Refusing to let Black history be buried twice

Suggested Taglines / Headline Copy

Eden held them. Eden holds us still.

Where Black memory lives.

Founded for dignity. Preserved for generations.

Founded for dignity. Preserved for us.

93,000 lives. ONE sacred Black archive.

The people who built Black Philadelphia are here.

From the ancestors to us.

Black history will NOT be buried twice.

A sacred landscape of Black life, memory, and freedom.

Audience Messaging

One Story, Different Doorways

The core narrative stays consistent; the reason to care changes by audience.

Audience	Key Messaging	Primary Call to Action
Black Philadelphians	Eden belongs inside the living cultural map of Black Philadelphia. It is a place to find ancestors, learn the city's Black institutional history, gather across generations, and claim a heritage that has repeatedly been displaced or minimized.	Visit. Bring family. Research your people. Join preservation efforts. Become a recurring supporter.
National audiences	Eden is a nationally significant Black historical landscape where the stories of abolition, voting rights, faith, medicine, architecture, military service, art, and civil rights converge. It is a place where American history can be understood through Black lives rather than appended as an aside.	Visit when in Philadelphia. Include Eden in educational and heritage itineraries. Support preservation.
Funders & Sponsors	Eden is both a preservation responsibility and a public history opportunity. Supporting Eden protects 93,000 individual records and a rare Black-controlled cultural landscape while expanding access, interpretation, education, and stewardship. Focus on Black change-agents and sponsoring their preservation.	Fund preservation, digitization, interpretation, programming, infrastructure, and visitor access.

Audience	Key Messaging	Primary Call to Action
Media	Eden offers a powerful reporting frame: what happens when Black communities create permanence in response to dispossession? Its story connects Jim Crow, cemetery displacement, Black institution-building, notable lives, descendant memory, and urgent preservation needs.	Cover Eden as a living Black institution — not only as a cemetery or during heritage months.

Proof Points to Repeat Consistently

- Founded in 1902 amid a Black burial crisis created by segregation, condemnation, urban expansion, and the closure of earlier Black cemeteries.
- 53 acres of Black-controlled sacred ground in Collingdale, Pennsylvania.
- More than 93,000 people are entrusted to Eden's care.
- A "collection cemetery" that received people reinterred from displaced Black burial grounds, including Lebanon and Olive.
- Lives at Eden span from the eighteenth century to the present, making the cemetery a multigenerational archive of Black life.
- National Register of Historic Places and National Underground Railroad Network to Freedom designations.
- Home to figures including Marian Anderson, Octavius V. Catto, William Still, Frances E. W. Harper, Rebecca J. Cole, Julian Abele, James Forten, Pauline Oberdorfer Minor, and Charles L. Blockson — alongside tens of thousands of less-famous community members whose lives are equally part of the record.

STRATEGIC SEQUENCING

Your Plan of Action

WORKSTREAM 1

Awareness: Website + sponsorship + community partnerships.

WORKSTREAM 2	Sustainability: Establish sponsorship and financial sustainability.
WORKSTREAM 3	Social Media: Build social media only when Eden has the capacity, content pipeline, governance, and response structure to sustain it.

Workstream 1 Awareness

Build Awareness Before Building Social

Near-term priority: make Eden easier to understand, easier to visit, easier to support, and easier to partner with.

1. Website: Make Eden's Significance Immediately Legible

- The website should function as Eden's primary narrative hub and conversion tool. Before expanding social media, every visitor, reporter, funder, descendant, educator, and partner should be able to understand Eden's story within seconds and know exactly what action to take next.
- Lead the homepage with the core positioning: Eden as a sacred Black cultural landscape created to preserve dignity and memory.
- Build clear pathways for Visit, Find an Ancestor / Grounds Map, Learn the History, Notable Residents, Tours & Education, and Support Eden.
- Use the "From the Ordinary to the Extraordinary" framework to prevent the site from becoming only a celebrity cemetery.
- Make the Beginnings story prominent: Lebanon and Olive, the burial crisis, the blocked gates, and the first burial demonstrate why Eden exists.
- Pair historical interpretation with visible donation and sponsorship opportunities throughout the site — not only on a single Donate page.
- Create a concise "Why Eden Matters" page that partners and media can easily cite and share.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

More people understand why Eden matters; more Black Philadelphians see Eden as part of their cultural inheritance; more institutions recognize a credible role for partnership; and awareness translates into the financial support needed to protect the cemetery for the next generation.

2. Community Partnerships: Restore Eden to the Cultural Map

Community engagement should make Eden feel less like a place people encounter only through death and more like a place Black communities can visit, learn, gather, and commune with memory.

- Develop recurring heritage days, family-history sessions, women's history programming, veteran remembrance, and thematic walking tours.
- Partner with Black churches, Divine Nine organizations, schools, HBCU alumni networks, neighborhood associations, genealogical groups, and Black cultural institutions.
- Use the phrase "That's ours" as a community ownership frame: Eden is a Black institution worth visiting, protecting, and claiming.
- Reintroduce traditions of cemetery visitation as reflection, learning, and ancestral connection — while respecting active burial operations and sacred space.
- Create community ambassador opportunities so trusted partners can bring their own audiences into Eden.
- *For a step-by-step approach to starting and testing a partnership, see [Appendix C](#).*

Workstream 2 Sponsorship & Financial Sustainability

Turn Cultural Importance Into Sustainable Support

Because preservation without resources is vulnerability. Sponsorship should be a primary brand activation, not an afterthought.

1. Sponsorship Positioning

Eden should not ask sponsors merely to "support a cemetery." The case for support is larger: sponsors are helping protect one of the most important repositories of Black Philadelphia's cultural memory, preserve 93,000 individual histories, expand public access to a nationally significant landscape, and ensure that Black-controlled sacred space survives for future generations.

CORE SPONSORSHIP MESSAGE

Preserving Eden means preserving evidence: names, families, institutions, stories, monuments, burial records, and the physical ground that connects Black Philadelphia's past to its future.

2. Priority Sponsorship Platforms

Preservation Partner: Support monument conservation, landscape care, archival protection, and preservation of historic sections.

Digital Memory Partner: Fund digitization of records, interactive mapping, searchable family-history resources, and interpretive storytelling.

Education Partner: Underwrite school visits, educator resources, student transportation, tours, and public-history programming.

Community Legacy Partner: Support free community days, genealogy events, women's programs, veteran remembrance, and intergenerational gatherings.

3. Who to Approach

- Philadelphia-region corporations with commitments to Black communities, historic preservation, education, or civic engagement.
- Foundations focused on African American history, archives, preservation, public humanities, genealogy, and place-based community development.
- Healthcare, architecture, higher education, arts, faith, and financial institutions whose own histories intersect with people buried at Eden.

4. Immediate 90-Day Brand Actions

- Finalize the brand narrative and "Why Eden Matters" language so every pitch uses one consistent story.
- Create a sponsorship one-sheet/deck with 4–5 fundable platforms and clear impact language.
- Revise the website homepage and support pathways to convert awareness into donations, sponsorship inquiries, tour bookings, and partnerships.
- Identify 20–30 priority institutional prospects and match each prospect to a specific sponsorship platform rather than sending a generic ask.
- Defer broad social-media expansion until Eden has the capacity to sustain it well.
- See [Appendix B](#) for the 90-Day Action Plan at a glance.

APPENDIX A

Elevator Pitches & Statement of Importance

Drafted from workshop voices, community input, and institutional history — June 2026

Why Eden Is Important — A Foundational Paragraph

Eden Cemetery is not simply a burial ground — it is the accumulated memory of Black America's most audacious act of self-determination.

Since Black Philadelphians began establishing their own sacred spaces in the 1790s — churches, beneficial societies, and cemeteries that offered dignity where the dominant culture offered none — they were building toward Eden.

Established in 1902 by Black founders who refused to accept that death would be another site of dispossession, Eden became the guardian of what other institutions could not hold. When Lebanon Cemetery and Olive Cemetery — home to Philadelphia's Black citizens — were forced to close and their residents reinterred, Eden absorbed them all.

What this means is that Eden now holds the complete record of Black Philadelphia's founding generation: the abolitionists who operated the Underground Railroad in plain sight, the ministers who built the first Black churches, the physicians who founded the first African American graduate medical programs, the poets who told America it could not be free while it held people in chains, the architects who designed the buildings of elite American institutions, and the musicians who carried the sorrow and joy of a people to the world's great stages.

Philadelphia was the civic laboratory of Black America — the city where Black people invented how to protest, how to claim rights, and how to build institutions that could sustain a community under conditions of profound oppression — and the people who did that are buried at Eden.

When you walk Eden's 53 acres, you are not visiting a cemetery. You are time-traveling through the foundation of Black American identity, standing on ground that holds 93,000 ordinary people who did extraordinary things — in a city that taught the world what freedom really means.

Ten Elevator Pitches

Each pitch offers a distinct angle. Phrases in italics are lifted directly from workshop participants.

01 The Founding Pitch

Philadelphia was the civic laboratory of Black America. The first HBCU. The first Black churches. The first beneficial societies. The first abolitionist networks that put the cracks in the foundation of American slavery. The men and women who built those institutions — who taught the world how to protest, how to claim civil rights, how to build a nation within a nation — are buried at Eden Cemetery. *You cannot do Black Philly history without Eden Cemetery.* And you cannot understand America without Black Philly.

02 The F.U.B.U. Pitch

In 1902, a group of Black Philadelphians did something radical: they built their own. For generations, Black people had been denied dignity in death — buried in unmarked graves, in segregated sections, in cemeteries they did not control. So Black Philadelphia built Eden. For You. By You. Ninety-three thousand souls rest on 53 acres of Black-owned, Black-controlled, sacred ground. *That's ours.* It has been ours from the beginning. It still is.

03 The Underground Railroad Pitch

William Still — the father of the Underground Railroad, the man who documented every freedom seeker he helped escape, who kept the records that became the foundation of African American genealogy — is buried at Eden. He is one of 93,000. Eden is a designated National Underground Railroad Network to Freedom site and is listed on the National Register of Historic Places. The freedom movement didn't end with emancipation. The proof is right here — *seeing what is no longer*, and what must never be forgotten.

04 The "Hi Oprah" Pitch (lifted directly from workshop)

"Hi Oprah. A serious historical injustice needs to be rectified. Eden Cemetery's significance has been strategically undermined — intentionally — and it has caused broken trust and lost community connections to Black American history, from the ordinary to the extraordinary, for over 124 years." Eden is where Stedman Graham's family rests. It is where Black Philadelphia rests. It needs a champion. We're asking you to be one.

05 The Time-Travel Pitch

What if you could sit in the same space as Marian Anderson, Frances Watkins Harper, and William Still? Eden Cemetery is *time travel – the past in the present*. It is where 93,000 stories of ordinary people who did extraordinary things are waiting to be heard. *Stories = History. Past = Now*. The result of what was is the continuation of what we are. Come sit with your ancestors. *History ignored is history repeated*. Eden won't let you forget.

06 The Civic Democracy Pitch

The Declaration of Independence was signed in Philadelphia. But it was Black Philadelphians who forced America to live up to it — who challenged its hypocrisy from the very beginning, in their churches, their courts, their newspapers, and their streets. What they practiced in Philadelphia, the world eventually practiced. *Philly is at the center of a national conversation about how American history should be remembered*. The architects of that tradition — *from the ordinary to the extraordinary, for over 124 years* — are buried at Eden. This is not a cemetery. It is the birthplace of American democracy's conscience.

07 The Sacred Space Pitch

Since the 1790s, Black Philadelphians have protected their right to honor their dead — in dignity, in community, in reverence. In a time when enslaved people had no control over their bodies in life or in death, having a headstone, having a grave someone could visit, having ancestors who had come to a place of rest — that was resistance. That was love. Eden is the culmination of over 200 years of that tradition. *A safe space. A sacred space. A third space*. Come honor them. Come sit in the beauty. *Come see what is no longer — and feel what endures*.

08 The Reinterment / Justice Pitch

Lebanon Cemetery. Olive Cemetery. The great Black burial grounds of Philadelphia — home to some of the most important Black Americans in history — were forced to close. Forced. Their residents were reinterred at Eden. Other cemeteries were not forced to move. Only theirs. *Even in death, the mistreatment continued*. But Eden held them. Eden holds them still. What looks like a cemetery is actually an act of resistance — 124 years of refusing to let Black history be buried twice.

09 The America's-Oldest-Black-Cemetery Pitch

Eden Cemetery is a representation of the importance of *the identity of Black life* — and one of the oldest continuously operating Black-founded cemeteries in the United States. Its 93,000 residents include an Olympic gold medalist, the composer of gospel's greatest hymns, a U.S. Congressman, the architect of elite American universities, the abolitionist who documented the Underground Railroad, and one of America's greatest singers. This is not a local story. *A representation of Black history — for half of America's history — has persisted here.* Eden is America.

10 The Future Pitch

We need Eden not just because of what happened in the past — but because of what is happening right now. Black spaces need support now more than ever. Eden is *how we transport the past to our future*. It is the place where we learn from the people who built Black America — who practiced *Afrofuturism* before the word existed, who imagined a future they might not live to see and built it anyway. *We need resources to continue informing future generations about our history.* We need Eden to survive — so the stories it holds can teach us *ways to improve our now*.

Key Phrases from the Community

Lifted verbatim from workshop participants — these are the people's words, ready for use in copy.

That's ours.

F.U.B.U. — For You, By You.

History ignored is history repeated.

Stories = History. Past = Now.

Time travel — the past in the present.

From the ordinary to the extraordinary.

Sitting with our ancestors.

Seeing what is no longer.

A historical Mecca.

Civil rights in death.

Sacred Black space.

How determination overpowers hardship.

You cannot do Black Philly history without Eden Cemetery.

It defines what it is to be a Black Philadelphian.

Where we cannot see them anywhere else.

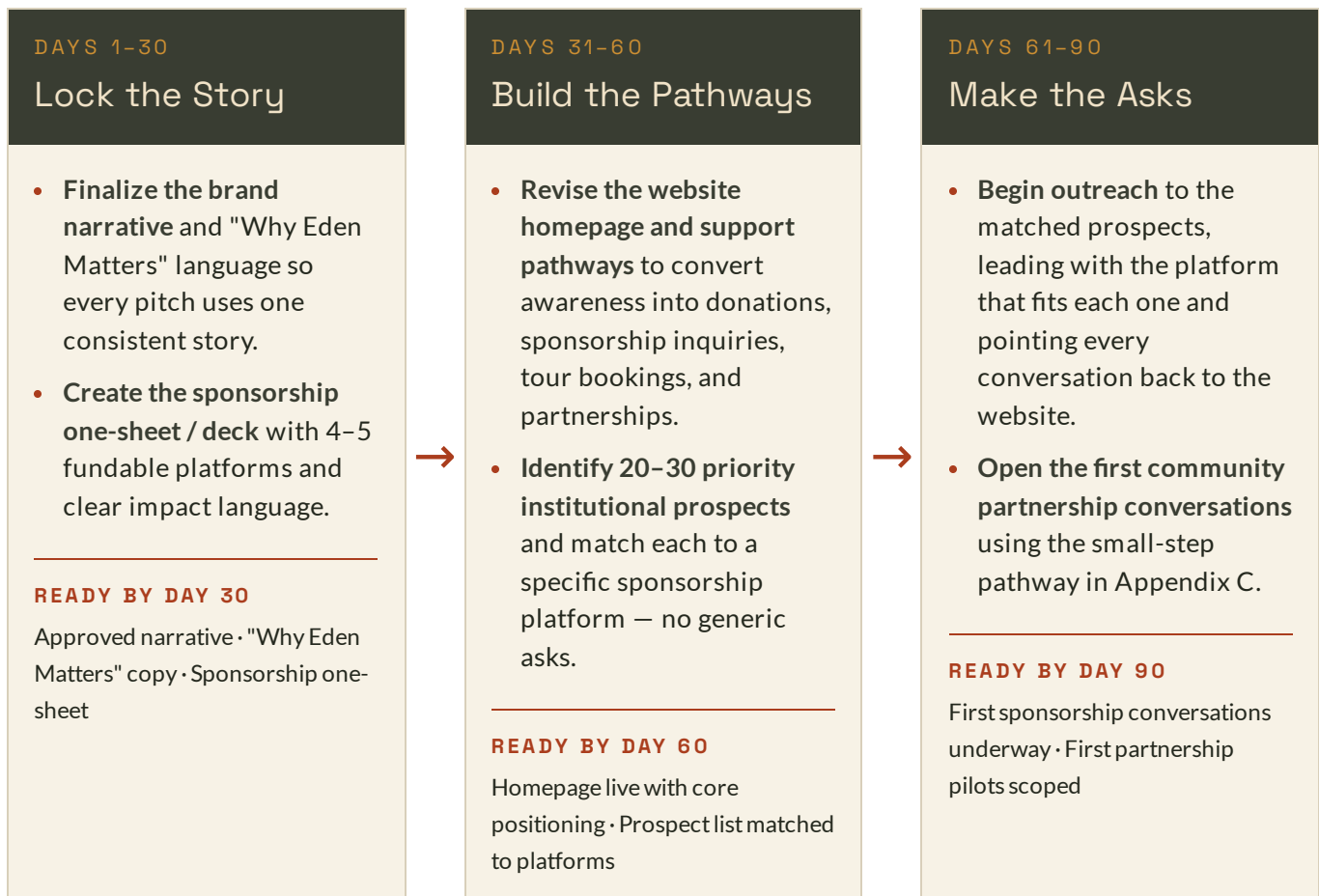
Hear uncomfortable stories to comfortability.

Stories are more important than history.

90-Day Action Plan

Turn the brand narrative into one consistent story, one set of tools, and a first round of matched asks.

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GUARDRAIL ALL 90 DAYS

Defer broad social-media expansion until Eden has the capacity, content pipeline, governance, and response structure to sustain it well. **Awareness first; social later.**

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

More people understand why Eden matters; more Black Philadelphians see Eden as part of their cultural inheritance; more institutions recognize a credible role for partnership; and awareness translates into the financial support needed to protect the cemetery for the next generation.

The four platforms every ask is matched to

Preservation Partner

Monument conservation, landscape care, archival protection, historic sections.

Digital Memory Partner

Digitized records, interactive mapping, searchable family history, interpretive storytelling.

Education Partner

School visits, educator resources, student transportation, tours, public-history programming.

Community Legacy Partner

Free community days, genealogy events, women's programs, veteran remembrance, gatherings.

One story. One set of tools. Matched asks — never a generic one.

Partnership Pathway

Start small, build the relationship while you work, then decide together whether to go deeper.

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1

REACH OUT

Open the door

Connect with a partner whose mission already touches Eden — a Black church, Divine Nine chapter, school, HBCU alumni network, neighborhood association, genealogical group, or cultural institution. Lead with the story, not the ask.

EDEN'S MOVE

- One warm introduction or direct note
- Share the "Why Eden Matters" page
- Ask for a conversation, not a commitment

2

START SMALL

Suggest one easy thing to do together

Propose a single, low-lift joint action with a clear date and a clear end — small enough that "yes" is easy, real enough that both sides learn something: a guided walking tour for their members, a family-history afternoon, a remembrance event, or a "That's ours" visit.

EDEN'S MOVE

- Offer two or three options; let them pick
- One event, one date
- Agree on who does what — briefly, in writing

3

BUILD THE RELATIONSHIP

Develop trust while you do the work

The joint action *is* the relationship-building. Plan it together, show up for each other, and notice how the partnership actually feels — communication, follow-through, shared values, and whether their people connect with Eden.

EDEN'S MOVE

- Co-plan, don't just host
- Thank them publicly and personally
- Hold a short, honest debrief



DECISION POINT

Is this a partnership worth continuing?

YES — GO DEEPER

Shared values, good follow-through, and their people showed up. Move to Step 4.

NOT YET — PART WARMLY

Thank them, keep the door open, and put your energy into the next partner. A small test that ends well is still a win.

4

DEEPEN

Build a pathway to sustainable work together

Turn a one-time action into a repeatable one: an annual program, a recurring tour or heritage day, a community-ambassador role, or a sponsorship match to one of the four platforms. Name the partnership, put it on both calendars, and agree on what sustained support looks like.

EDEN'S MOVE

- Propose a recurring rhythm
- Invite them to become an ambassador
- Match them to a sponsorship platform

Test small. Learn fast. Grow only the partnerships that prove themselves.



SECTION 2

Tour

Bringing the brand narrative onto the grounds. Two guided walks, told through Eden's section names.

Learning Black History Through Burial Grounds

A walking tour of Eden. Eight stops, from the first burial in 1902 to the present.

PREPARED BY 1838 BLACK METROPOLIS · RECLAIM. REWRITE. & RESTORE.

The question this tour asks

Eden was founded on June 20, 1902, when the Commonwealth of Pennsylvania chartered the Eden Cemetery Company and Black civic leaders purchased roughly 53 acres in Collingdale. It was created partly in response to segregation and to the displacement of Black burial grounds in Philadelphia. It holds both relocated burials and people buried directly at Eden, and its plot names are themselves a commemoration of Black history. Every stop on this walk returns to one question.

How does Eden continue the tradition of preserving generations of Black life, Black Community Building, and Black Institution Building?

Tour at a glance

Tour title Learning Black History Through Burial Grounds: A Walking Tour of Eden

Length 90–120 minutes

Audience General audience

Starting location Springfield Road entrance

Ending location John Brown, or return to the entrance

Stops 8

Tour at a glance

Walking level	Visitors able to walk and stand for a longer period
Content advisory	Discussion of grave disturbance, racism, and reinterment
Guide materials	Printed route sheet, section map, timer, emergency contact

How each stop is told

The same six beats at every plot. The stops differ in length and in the people they center, but the structure never changes. That is what lets a guide keep the walk coherent across eight sections and two centuries.

- **How the plot received its name.** What or whom it commemorates; whether it was named for a person, a displaced cemetery, an institution, or a historical figure; when it was established or in use, if known; and whether the namesake is actually buried there.
- **Introduce a few people buried there.** Connect their history to Eden through death and burial. Example sequence: “[Name], who passed [date], was originally buried at [place]. Their remains were [transferred to Eden with that cemetery / buried directly at Eden / moved separately to Eden / later removed from Eden].” Then explain their legacy.
- **Connect that person to someone at another stop.** “[Name] worked with [person], whom we will encounter later in the [plot] section,” or “This takes us back to [person], whom we discussed in the [plot] section.” Gesture toward the earlier or upcoming plot or headstone whenever it is visible.
- **Additional detail.** Add one or two people who deepen the central person’s network or extend the chronology.
- **If time permits.** Offer a lesser-known person; a theme connecting everyone, such as medicine, education, religion, art, or fraternal life; or a larger historical issue, such as body-snatching, cemetery displacement, scientific racism, or commemoration.
- **Transition.** End by explaining why the group is moving to the next plot.

Three tiers of content. Every line in this script sits in one of them.

- **Confirmed.** Ready to say to the public.
- **Optional detail.** Confirmed, but expendable if time is short.
- **Research note.** Promising but not ready for public interpretation. **Do not say it on the tour.**

Burial-status tags. The tags below mark how each person came to be at Eden. Say the distinction aloud; it is the teaching device of the whole tour.

Tag	Meaning
Transferred	Moved to Eden with an earlier cemetery (Lebanon 1903, Olive 1923, Stephen Smith Home 1903).
Direct Eden burial	Buried at Eden after the section was established.
Remains now elsewhere	Former Eden interment or memorial; the remains have since been moved.
Sequence unconfirmed	Burial history still needs confirmation in Eden’s records before it is said aloud.

The route at a glance

Stop	Purpose	Central people
Introduction	Establishes 1902 as the tour’s organizing pivot. Explains Eden as a collection cemetery, an active cemetery, and a cultural landscape.	Eden’s founders, collectively
1. Celestine	Name, first interment, and resistance to Eden.	Celestine Moseley Cromwell
2. Richard Allen	Flashes back to 1787– 1831. Black religious control of death and burial before Eden.	Richard Allen; Absalom Jones
3. Lehmann	Returns to 1902 and Eden’s founding. Creation and administration of Eden.	Martin J. Lehmann; the five founders
4. Lebanon	Moves from 1818 through the twentieth century. Displacement, reinterment, and dense intergenerational networks.	James Forten; William Still
5. John Brown	Connects abolition, Civil War memory, and 1911. Burial location as political memory.	Frances Ellen Watkins Harper; Black veterans

Stop	Purpose	Central people
6. Bowers	Centers death care and a Black woman's business leadership. Black funeral work and control over burial.	Henrietta Bowers Duterte
7. Olive	Moves from nineteenth-century reform to twentieth-century arts. A second displaced cemetery and intellectual inheritance.	William Whipper; Jessie Redmon Fauset
8. Celestine revisited	Extends the story from 1922 to 2023. Eden as the chosen burial place of later generations.	Rebecca J. Cole; Marian Anderson; Charles L. Blockson
Closing	Brings the story to the present. Stewardship, contested reinterment, and unresolved responsibility.	MOVE children; First African Baptist remains; Morton Collection individuals

Start Springfield Road entrance

3–5 minutes. Welcome the group to Eden. Explain the length, the terrain, and the basic route.

Guide script. Eden was founded on June 20, 1902, when the Commonwealth of Pennsylvania chartered the Eden Cemetery Company. Black civic leaders purchased approximately 53 acres of land here in Collingdale to establish it. Eden was created partly in response to segregation and the displacement of Black burial grounds. It contains both relocated burials and people buried directly at Eden, and its plot names serve as a commemoration of Black history.

Set the question. “The key question we will think about is: How does Eden continue the tradition of preserving generations of Black life, Black Community Building, and Black Institution Building?”

01 Celestine

7–10 minutes. Chronological span 1902–1976. Central theme: Eden's first burial and white resistance. Central person: Celestine Moseley Cromwell. **Direct Eden burial.**

About this plot. The Celestine section was named for Celestine Moseley Cromwell, Eden Cemetery's first burial. She was the wife of Willis H. Cromwell, one of the twenty-nine members of the Eden Cemetery Company's advisory board.

Optional detail. Celestine Reserve No. 1 and Celestine Reserve No. 2 are later expansions of the original section. The date of Reserve No. 1 is not documented in the National Register nomination; Reserve No. 2 dates to 1976.

Her death and burial. Celestine Moseley Cromwell died on August 8, 1902. Eden planned to bury her on August 12, but white Collingdale residents and borough officials attempted to prevent the funeral procession from entering the new Black cemetery. Her remains were held for approximately thirty-six hours before she was finally buried at Eden on August 14, 1902.

Who had the authority to decide where Black bodies could be buried, and whether those places would remain protected?

Walking transition, Celestine to Lehmann (5–8 minutes). Introduce the section-name categories and the cemetery’s geography as you walk.

In early America, free and enslaved Black Philadelphians were frequently buried in public, marginal, segregated, or poorly marked spaces. Black communities had limited legal control over burial land, which left graves vulnerable to disturbance and erasure. This was a form of oppression African Americans dealt with throughout their history.

To counter it, in the 1790s and 1800s independent Black churches established churchyards and burial arrangements. Church burial grounds were among the earliest spaces over which Black Philadelphians exercised institutional and spiritual control. Mutual-aid organizations also helped Black communities assume collective responsibility for death and burial. One of the plots we will see is named for Richard Allen, who in 1787, alongside Absalom Jones and others, established the Free African Society, which provided mutual aid, care for the sick, and burial assistance.

02 Richard Allen

7–9 minutes. Chronological span 1787 to the present. Central theme: religious institution-building and control over burial. Main connection: Richard Allen to Absalom Jones to Lebanon.

About this plot. The Richard Allen section is named in honor of Richard Allen, founder and first bishop of the African Methodist Episcopal Church. The plot commemorates him, but his remains are not here. Say that distinction right after the plot name: “Richard Allen gives this section its name, but he is not buried here. His remains are entombed at Mother Bethel AME Church in Philadelphia.”

Legacy. In 1787, Allen, Absalom Jones, and other Black Philadelphians established the Free African Society. It provided mutual aid, assistance to the sick, and support surrounding death and burial. In 1810, Mother Bethel acquired the Bethel Burying Ground. Thousands of Black Philadelphians were buried there through the nineteenth century. Mother Bethel later sold the property, and the site eventually became part of Weccacoe Playground, while thousands of remains apparently remained beneath the transformed landscape.

Jones’s and Allen’s passing. Allen’s collaborator Absalom Jones died in 1818. Jones’s remains were moved several times, including from Lebanon Cemetery to Eden. “When we reach the Lebanon section, we will follow that complicated burial journey.” Richard Allen died on March 26, 1831. He was buried at Mother Bethel AME Church, where his remains are now held in a sarcophagus, a stone coffin above ground, in the church’s lower-level museum.

Transition to Lehmann. “Allen and Jones created institutions to care for Black Philadelphians when white institutions would not. More than a century later, Martin Lehmann and Eden’s other founders confronted the same fundamental problem on the scale of an entire cemetery.”

03 Lehmann

6–8 minutes. Chronological span 1859–1924. Central theme: building and administering Eden.

About this plot. The Lehmann section is named for Martin J. Lehmann (1859–1924), a cigar maker who served as treasurer of the Eden Cemetery Company. Lehmann was one of Eden’s five charter members, whom Eden identifies collectively as its founders.

Founder	Office
John C. Asbury	President
Charles W. Jones	Vice president
Daniel W. Parvis	Vice president
Jerome Bacon	Secretary
Martin J. Lehmann	Treasurer

What Lehmann represents. Not merely a person for whom a plot was named, but the financial and administrative work required to create a Black-controlled cemetery: obtaining a charter; acquiring land;

defending the cemetery legally; selling and recording plots; arranging burials and transfers; and sustaining the cemetery as an institution.

Research note. The National Register nomination confirms that the section was named for Lehmann but does not establish its exact naming date. It classifies Lehmann as a “newer” section and indicates that it was being used substantially by 1958. It also cautions that a section’s naming may have occurred after burials began there. **Do not say that Lehmann is buried in the Lehmann section until his exact grave location is confirmed.** The documented point is that the section was named for him.

04 Lebanon

15–20 minutes. Central themes: cemetery displacement, reinterment, civil-rights networks, Black control over burial. Principal nodes: James Forten and William Still. Optional clusters: Absalom Jones; Catto and LeCount; the Still-Anderson family; Black medicine.

First, gather and orient the group. *[Position the group where visitors can see the Lebanon sign and as much of the section as possible. Allow everyone to settle before beginning.]*

We are now standing at the Lebanon section, one of the most historically important sections at Eden. Lebanon is not named for a famous individual. It preserves the name of an entire Black cemetery that no longer exists. *[Pause and gesture across the section.]* The people buried here did not all arrive in the same way. Some were removed from Lebanon Cemetery in Philadelphia and transferred here in 1903. Others were buried directly at Eden years or decades later. That distinction, between a transferred ancestor and a later Eden burial, will help us understand this section.

Second, how Lebanon received its name. Lebanon Cemetery was chartered in Philadelphia on January 24, 1849. It stood near what is now Nineteenth Street and Snyder Avenue in South Philadelphia. It was a nonsectarian cemetery created for African Americans who were excluded from many white cemeteries. Its establishment represented progress: Black Philadelphians had secured a dedicated place in which members of their community could be buried. But ownership and designation did not guarantee permanent protection.

In 1882, newspapers exposed an organized body-snatching operation at Lebanon. Bodies had been removed from graves and sold to Jefferson Medical College for anatomical study. In 1899, Philadelphia condemned Lebanon Cemetery. As the city expanded, the land occupied by the cemetery became valuable for other uses. When Eden opened, thousands of remains were removed from Lebanon and brought here. By 1903, the original cemetery had closed.

The name “Lebanon” does more than identify this section. It preserves the name of a Black place that was erased from Philadelphia’s physical landscape.

Third, Absalom Jones: a burial journey spanning four places. *[Gesture back toward the Richard Allen section.]* At the Richard Allen section, we discussed the Free African Society, which Richard Allen, Absalom Jones, and others established in 1787. Absalom Jones died on February 13, 1818.

Remains now elsewhere. He was first buried in the churchyard of the African Episcopal Church of St. Thomas, the church he helped establish with assistance from James Forten and other members of Philadelphia’s Black community. When that church moved, Jones’s remains were transferred to Lebanon Cemetery. When Lebanon closed, his remains were transferred again, from Lebanon to Eden. In 1991, Jones’s remains were removed from Eden and returned to the African Episcopal Church of St. Thomas. Jones’s journey demonstrates that reinterment was not always a single event. Some Black remains traveled through several burial landscapes as churches moved, cemeteries closed, and cities changed.

Fourth, James Forten: the central nineteenth-century node. Another person connecting Jones to this section is James Forten. James Forten died on March 4, 1842.

Transferred. Forten was originally buried at the African Episcopal Church of St. Thomas at Fifth and Adelphi Streets. His remains were subsequently moved to Lebanon Cemetery and eventually transferred here to Eden. *[Gesture toward Forten’s marker or in its general direction.]* Forten was born in Philadelphia in 1766. As a young man, he served aboard an American privateer during the Revolutionary War. He later became a successful sailmaker, employer, abolitionist, and supporter of Black education. He is especially valuable to this tour because he connects several generations and several sections of Eden.

- **Connection backward to Absalom Jones.** Forten helped Absalom Jones establish the African Episcopal Church of St. Thomas in 1794. He also supported schools for Black children and adults. Religious independence, education, mutual aid, and burial were not separate projects. They were different parts of building an independent Black community.
- **Optional: connection forward to William Whipper at Olive.** *[Gesture toward Olive if visible; otherwise in the direction the tour will travel.]* Later, at the Olive section, we will meet William Whipper. Forten and Whipper participated in the American Moral Reform Society, concerned with abolition, education, temperance, economic advancement, and collective responsibility. Forten died in 1842 and Whipper in 1876. They belonged to overlapping generations: Forten helped create institutions that Whipper’s generation entered, expanded, and sometimes challenged.

- **Optional: connection within Lebanon to James J. G. Bias.** James Joshua Gould Bias died on July 15, 1860. **Transferred.** Bias was originally buried at Lebanon Cemetery and was transferred to Eden when the cemetery was displaced. He was a physician, minister, abolitionist, Vigilance Committee leader, and participant in the Colored Conventions movement. Convention records place Bias, Whipper, and Stephen Smith within the same larger movement of Black political organization.

Memory cue. Jones helped build religious independence. Forten connected religious, educational, and abolitionist work. Bias joined medicine to abolition and political organizing. Whipper and Smith connected reform to business and economic power.

Fifth, Octavius Catto: murder, voting, and reinterment. *[Shift the group's attention or move a few steps if Catto's location can be indicated.]* Octavius Valentine Catto died on October 10, 1871.

Transferred. He was originally buried at Lebanon Cemetery. His remains were transferred to Eden on May 14, 1903. Catto was only thirty-two when he was murdered during election-day racial violence in Philadelphia. His work brought together education, voting rights, Black military service, streetcar desegregation, baseball, and public commemoration.

- **Connection to William Still.** Catto worked within the same Philadelphia civil-rights network as William Still. Both participated in the campaign to desegregate the city's streetcars.
- **Connection to Caroline LeCount.** Catto was engaged to educator and activist Caroline LeCount. LeCount died on January 24, 1923. **Direct Eden burial.** Unlike Catto, LeCount was not transferred here with Lebanon Cemetery. She died twenty years after the transfer and was buried directly at Eden in the section where Catto had been reinterred. This is one of the clearest examples of the distinction we are following. Catto was moved here because Lebanon Cemetery was closed. LeCount was later buried here after Lebanon had become an Eden section. Their presence in the same section reunites two connected lives, but their bodies arrived through different historical processes.
- **Optional memory cue.** Catto represents displacement. LeCount represents return, or reunion.

Sixth, William Still: the generational bridge. William Still died on July 14, 1902, about one month before Celestine Cromwell's burial opened Eden.

Sequence unconfirmed. Still is recorded as buried at Eden, but the precise sequence between his death and interment should be confirmed in Eden's first interment register before the guide states that Eden was unquestionably his first burial location. **Until the record is checked, do not label Still as transferred or as a direct burial in the spoken tour. Say only that he is buried here.**

Still was an abolitionist, Underground Railroad organizer, businessman, writer, and historian. His 1872 book, *The Underground Rail Road*, preserved accounts of hundreds of freedom seekers and the people who assisted them. He connects multiple sections of the tour.

- **Backward to James Forten.** Still belonged to a later generation of Philadelphia abolitionists. Forten's generation built many of the religious, educational, and reform institutions through which Still's generation worked.
- **To John Brown, back or forward depending on route.** Still worked with Frances Ellen Watkins Harper in Philadelphia's abolitionist community. Harper is buried in the John Brown section.
- **To Catto and LeCount.** Still, Catto, and LeCount participated in the struggle to desegregate Philadelphia streetcars.
- **To the Still-Anderson family.** Still also connects abolition to the emergence of Black-controlled medical and social-service institutions. His daughter, Caroline Still Anderson, died on June 1, 1919. **Direct Eden burial.** She was buried directly at Eden in the Lebanon section. Caroline was a physician and educator. Her husband, Matthew Anderson, was a Presbyterian minister and the founder of Berean Presbyterian Church. *[Gesture back toward Celestine.]* Matthew Anderson is buried in Celestine, which we encountered at the beginning of the tour. Together, Caroline and Matthew developed medical, educational, religious, and social-service programs through Berean.

The Still-Anderson family connects two plots and two generations. William Still represents abolition and the Underground Railroad. Caroline Still Anderson represents medicine and education. Matthew Anderson represents religion and community institution-building.

Optional deep dive: the Black medical network. *[Use only if approximately four or more minutes remain.]* The Lebanon section contains a legacy of Black medical and public-health history.

- **Caroline Still Anderson** died on June 1, 1919. She was one of the earliest Black women physicians in Philadelphia.
- **Nathan Francis Mossell** died on October 27, 1946. **Direct Eden burial.** He was buried at Eden long after the Lebanon transfer. Mossell became the first Black graduate of the University of Pennsylvania's medical school and founded Frederick Douglass Memorial Hospital, which offered care to Black patients while creating professional opportunities for Black physicians and nurses excluded from many white institutions.
- **Gertrude Bustill Mossell** died on January 21, 1948. **Direct Eden burial.** She was a journalist, author, educator, suffragist, and fundraiser, and helped generate support for the hospital her husband founded. Together, the Mossells show that institution-building required more than a physician. It required writing, fundraising, public persuasion, women's organizing, and community trust.
- **Connection back to Celestine.** Rebecca J. Cole, buried in Celestine, also belonged to Philadelphia's pioneering generation of Black women physicians. The evidence establishes a shared professional world, but not every proposed personal relationship among Cole, Anderson, and Mossell has been

confirmed. **Describe them as an overlapping medical network, not automatically as close friends or collaborators.**

Optional deep dive: Laura Wheeler Waring. Laura Wheeler Waring died on February 3, 1948. **Direct Eden burial.** She was a later direct burial at Eden, not a person transferred from the original Lebanon Cemetery. Waring was a painter and educator known especially for her portraits of prominent Black Americans. She gives the guide two connections. *[Gesture toward Olive.]* Jessie Redmon Fauset, whom we will meet at Olive, was Waring’s friend and traveling companion; they traveled together in Europe and North Africa. *[Gesture back toward Celestine.]* Waring also painted Marian Anderson, who is buried in Celestine. Waring at Lebanon, Fauset at Olive, Anderson at Celestine: three sections, one friendship and one portrait.

Lebanon summary. *[Bring the group’s attention back to the whole plot.]* Lebanon contains several different kinds of burial history. Absalom Jones’s remains passed through this section and were later returned to St. Thomas. James Forten, James Bias, and Octavius Catto were transferred after earlier burial grounds closed. Caroline LeCount, Caroline Still Anderson, the Mossells, and Laura Wheeler Waring were buried at Eden later, after Lebanon had become one of its established sections. The plot therefore represents both displacement and continuity. The dead moved here from a place that disappeared. Later generations then chose, or were given, burial among them.

Transition out of Lebanon. “Lebanon preserves the name of a lost Black cemetery. Our next stop shows another way a plot name can communicate memory: it could express allegiance to a historical figure and the unfinished struggle that figure represented.” *[Move toward John Brown.]*

05 John Brown

Main node: Frances Ellen Watkins Harper. Chronological anchor: February 22, 1911. **Direct Eden burial.**

Open with the distinction. “John Brown gives this section its name, but he is not buried here.” Then introduce Harper: “Frances Ellen Watkins Harper died on February 22, 1911, and was buried directly at Eden in the John Brown section.”

Why the location matters. Her burial location carried political meaning. Harper regarded Brown as a friend and hero. She was also close to William Still through Philadelphia’s abolitionist and Underground Railroad networks, which connects this stop back to Lebanon.

Optional cluster. The United States Colored Troops, and the use of cemetery space to preserve Civil War memory.

06 Bowers

About this plot. This section was named for Henrietta Bowers Duterte, identified as America's first Black woman undertaker, not for her brother John C. Bowers.

Optional detail. "A sign reading only 'Bowers' does not tell us which Bowers is being commemorated. Eden's National Register documentation identifies Henrietta Bowers Duterte, a pioneering undertaker, business owner, abolitionist, and philanthropist."

John C. Bowers. Died in 1873. **Transferred.** He was originally buried at Lebanon Cemetery and was later transferred to Eden.

07 Olive

13–18 minutes. Central themes: a displaced cemetery, intergenerational inheritance, reform, literature, folklore, and religion. Principal figures: William Whipper and Jessie Redmon Fauset. Optional figures: Stephen Smith, Arthur Huff Fauset, Joseph Brister. Central comparison: Whipper was transferred with Olive; Fauset was buried later in Eden's Olive section.

First, gather and orient the group. *[Stop at the Olive sign. Let the group face the section before speaking.]* Like Lebanon, Olive preserves the name of an earlier African American cemetery in Philadelphia. It is important to distinguish between Olive Cemetery, the original Philadelphia burial ground, and Olive, the section here at Eden. The original cemetery dates to 1849. The remaining burials were transferred to Eden in 1923. So 1923 is not the year Olive Cemetery was established. It is the year its dead were brought here.

Second, how Olive received its name. Olive Cemetery stood in West Philadelphia near Forty-fourth Street and Girard Avenue. It was associated with Black abolitionist, businessman, minister, and philanthropist Stephen Smith. Smith used wealth generated through business to support Black institutions, including the Philadelphia Home for Aged and Infirm Colored Persons. The Home maintained its own burial ground nearby. The dead from the Stephen Smith Home burial ground were brought to Eden in 1903. The remaining burials from Olive Cemetery followed in 1923. *[Gesture over the section.]* As at Lebanon, some people in this section were transferred with the old cemetery. Others died later and were buried directly in the Eden section.

Third, William Whipper: transferred with Olive. William Whipper died on March 9, 1876. **Transferred.** He was originally buried at Olive Cemetery. His remains were transferred to Eden when the old cemetery was removed. Whipper was an entrepreneur, abolitionist, moral reformer, convention activist, and Underground Railroad participant.

- **Connection back to James Forten at Lebanon.** *[Gesture back toward Lebanon.]* At Lebanon, we met James Forten. Forten and Whipper participated in the American Moral Reform Society, which joined abolition to questions about education, economic life, temperance, print culture, and collective responsibility. Forten was born in 1766, Whipper in 1804. Their work overlapped, but they also represent successive generations of Black reform.
- **Connection to Stephen Smith.** Whipper's strongest professional and personal connection was Stephen Smith. Smith and Whipper became partners in a highly successful lumber and coal business. Their business interests helped support their antislavery activities, including Underground Railroad work. The relationship was also familial: Whipper married Smith's sister, Harriet. Smith and Whipper show that Black economic history and abolitionist history cannot be separated neatly. Their businesses created money, transportation networks, property, and relationships that could be mobilized for antislavery work.

Memory cue. Forten helped establish the reform network. Smith supplied economic and institutional power. Whipper connected business, reform, and transportation.

Fourth, Jessie Redmon Fauset. Now we move forward eighty-five years. Jessie Redmon Fauset died on April 30, 1961. **Direct Eden burial.** Unlike Whipper, Fauset was not moved here from the original Olive Cemetery. She died decades after the transfer and was buried directly in Eden's Olive section. Whipper's remains came here because a cemetery was displaced. Fauset came here after Olive had become part of Eden's commemorative landscape.

Fauset's legacy. Fauset was a novelist, poet, teacher, translator, and literary editor. As literary editor of the NAACP's *The Crisis*, she helped publish and encourage writers associated with what became known as the Harlem Renaissance. Her presence extends Olive's story from nineteenth-century abolition and moral reform into twentieth-century literature, education, and Black cultural production. She also helps us see historical inheritance. Fauset did not personally continue Whipper's lumber business or abolitionist work. But she inherited a world shaped by generations of Black institution-building, education, organizing, and print culture.

- **Connection back to Laura Wheeler Waring at Lebanon.** *[Gesture back toward Lebanon.]* At Lebanon, we encountered painter Laura Wheeler Waring. Fauset and Waring were friends. They traveled together in Europe and North Africa, including a documented trip to Algiers in 1914. Fauset helped shape how Black life appeared in literature and print. Waring helped shape how Black people appeared through portraiture.
- **Connection back to Marian Anderson at Celestine.** Waring painted Marian Anderson, whom we encountered, or will encounter again, at Celestine. Literature, visual art, and music are connected across the cemetery.

Additional detail: Arthur Huff Fauset. Jessie's younger half-brother, Arthur Huff Fauset, is also buried at Olive. Arthur Fauset died on September 2, 1983. **Direct Eden burial.** Like Jessie, he was buried directly at Eden decades after the 1923 transfer. Arthur was an educator, civil-rights activist, anthropologist, and folklorist. His book *Black Gods of the Metropolis* examined Black religious communities in Philadelphia. The siblings provide two related forms of cultural documentation: Jessie studied and shaped Black life through literature and editing; Arthur studied Black life through folklore, anthropology, religion, and education.

Optional deep dive: religion and the Fauset family. *[Use if the group has expressed interest in religion.]* Jessie and Arthur were children of Redmon Fauset, an African Methodist Episcopal minister. But shared family origins did not mean identical beliefs. Jessie described a strongly religious upbringing. Arthur later became critical of organized religion even while studying Black religious traditions. A religious family can transmit a common language and institutional background without producing identical adult beliefs. Arthur's research preserved information about religious communities that larger academic institutions often ignored.

Optional deep dive: from reform organizations to cultural institutions. *[Use if time remains.]* Whipper and Fauset lived in different centuries, but both depended on Black-controlled or Black-oriented institutions. Whipper worked through abolitionist societies, moral-reform organizations, convention networks, businesses, and Underground Railroad relationships. Fauset worked through schools, the NAACP, *The Crisis*, literary networks, and Pan-African organizing. The specific institutions changed, but the underlying practice continued: Black people created organizations through which they could circulate resources, knowledge, art, and political ideas.

Optional audience questions. "What changes when a displaced cemetery's name is retained, even though its original land is gone?" "Do you think Whipper and Fauset belong to the same historical story, even though they died eighty-five years apart?"

Olive summary. *[Return attention to the section as a whole.]* Olive contains two overlapping histories. The first is displacement. William Whipper and others were removed from an African American cemetery in Philadelphia and brought here in 1923. The second is continuity. Jessie and Arthur Fauset were buried directly at Eden after Olive became an established section. Whipper connects Olive backward to Forten, Smith, abolition, business, and the Colored Conventions. Jessie and Arthur Fauset connect it forward to literature, education, folklore, religion, visual art, and the Harlem Renaissance.

The name of a lost cemetery became the name of a new community of the dead.

Transition from Olive, if returning to Celestine. “We began with the struggle to complete Eden’s first burial. We will now return to Celestine to see what Eden became after that first confrontation: a chosen resting place for later generations of Black artists, physicians, religious leaders, and preservers of history.”

If Olive is the final plot. “Olive brings together people who were forced to move after death and people who later chose, or whose families chose, to make Eden their resting place. That combination of displacement and continuity defines Eden as a whole.”

08 Closing: Celestine revisited

The return. We began here with a woman whose burial was resisted in 1902. We return to find generations of Black professionals, artists, ministers, and historians who subsequently made Eden their place of rest. All four people below were later burials, not people transferred when Eden opened. That is the bridge into the closing discussion of present-day stewardship and contested reinterment.

Death	Person	Function in the conclusion
August 14, 1922	Rebecca J. Cole	Black women’s medical leadership
January 11, 1928	Matthew Anderson	Berean institutions; connection to Caroline Still Anderson at Lebanon
April 8, 1993	Marian Anderson	Music, civil rights, and international cultural prominence
June 14, 2023	Charles L. Blockson	Historical collecting and the preservation of Black memory

Closing discussion. Stewardship, contested reinterment, and unresolved responsibility: the MOVE children; the First African Baptist remains; the Morton Collection individuals. [TBD: closing script to be written by the tour team.]

Learning Black History Through Burial Grounds

A walking tour of Eden. Three to four stops, short distances, richer stories.

PREPARED BY 1838 BLACK METROPOLIS · RECLAIM. REWRITE. & RESTORE.

The question this tour asks

This is the same tour as the full walk, built for a smaller loop and a group that may not want to stand for long. Short walking distances, a seated interpretation point wherever possible, fewer stops with richer stories, and terrain conditions stated plainly at the start. The people who open Eden's story, Celestine Cromwell and Martin Lehmann, are introduced at the parking area rather than at their sections.

How did Black Philadelphians create dignified places for burial when older burial grounds were threatened or destroyed?

Tour at a glance

Length 60 minutes

Audience General audience; limited-mobility audience

Starting location [TBD] To be confirmed

Ending location [TBD] To be confirmed

Stops 3–4

Walking level Limited walking. Portable chairs welcome and suggested.

Content advisory Discussion of grave disturbance, racism, and reinterment

Tour at a glance

Guide materials

Printed route sheet, section map, timer, emergency contact

Things for guides to consider on this tour

- **Short walking distances.** Point out the Richard Allen and Lebanon sections from the parking area so the group can see where it is going.
- **A seated interpretation point whenever possible.** Welcome visitors to sit.
- **Fewer stops with richer stories.** Lebanon carries most of the tour.
- **Clearly stated terrain conditions.** State the tour's length and the actual terrain before setting out.

Three tiers of content. Every line in this script sits in one of them.

- **Confirmed.** Ready to say to the public.
- **Optional detail.** Confirmed, but expendable if time is short.
- **Research note.** Promising but not ready for public interpretation. **Do not say it on the tour.**

Burial-status tags. Say the distinction aloud; it is the teaching device of the whole tour.

Tag	Meaning
Transferred	Moved to Eden with an earlier cemetery (Lebanon 1903, Olive 1923, Stephen Smith Home 1903).
Direct Eden burial	Buried at Eden after the section was established.
Remains now elsewhere	Former Eden interment or memorial; the remains have since been moved.
Sequence unconfirmed	Burial history still needs confirmation in Eden's records before it is said aloud.

Start Introduction at the parking area

Guide cue. Welcome visitors at the parking area. State the tour's length and actual terrain, then point out the Richard Allen and Lebanon sections where the group will stop. Welcome visitors to sit.

Guide script. Eden was founded in 1902 by five Black civic leaders who wanted a dignified burial place for African Americans. They were responding both to exclusion from burial spaces and to the displacement of older Black cemeteries in Philadelphia.

Two people we won't visit today help tell Eden's opening story. Celestine Moseley Cromwell died on August 8, 1902. She was meant to be Eden's first burial, but white opposition in Collingdale delayed her funeral. She was finally buried at Eden on August 14. The Celestine section bears her name. Martin J. Lehmann died in 1924. He had served as treasurer and was one of Eden's five founders. The Lehmann section bears his name. Celestine's burial and Lehmann's work remind us that creating Eden required both a public fight for the right to bury the dead and the ongoing work of building a cemetery.

Today we'll see two ways a section can carry history. The Richard Allen section honors a Black religious leader who is not buried at Eden. Lebanon preserves the name of an earlier Black cemetery whose dead were brought here from Philadelphia. Within Eden's sections, we also find people who were buried here directly, years after the sections were established.

Group question. "How does Eden continue the tradition of preserving generations of Black life, Black Community Building, and Black Institution Building?"

Optional detail, if time permits. Name the other four founders alongside Lehmann: John C. Asbury, Charles W. Jones, Daniel W. Parvis, and Jerome Bacon. You could also note that Celestine's husband served on Eden's advisory board.

Research note. **Do not say that Lehmann is buried in the Lehmann section until his exact grave location is confirmed.** The documented point needed for this introduction is that the section was named for him.

01 Richard Allen

7–9 minutes. Chronological span 1787 to the present. Central theme: religious institution-building and control over burial. Main connection: Richard Allen to Absalom Jones to Lebanon.

Plot name. The Richard Allen section is named in honor of Richard Allen, founder and first bishop of the African Methodist Episcopal Church. The plot commemorates him, but his remains are not here. That distinction should come immediately after the plot name: "Richard Allen gives this section its name, but he is not buried here. His remains are entombed at Mother Bethel AME Church in Philadelphia."

Death and burial. Richard Allen died on March 26, 1831. He was buried at Mother Bethel AME Church, where his remains are now held in a sarcophagus in the church's lower-level museum.

Legacy. In 1787, Allen, Absalom Jones, and other Black Philadelphians established the Free African Society. It provided mutual aid, assistance to the sick, and support surrounding death and burial. In 1810, Mother Bethel acquired the Bethel Burying Ground. Thousands of Black Philadelphians were buried there through the nineteenth century. Mother Bethel later sold the property, and the site eventually became part of Weccacoe Playground, while thousands of remains apparently remained beneath the transformed landscape.

Connection forward. “Allen’s collaborator Absalom Jones died in 1818. Jones’s remains were moved several times, including from Lebanon Cemetery to Eden. When we reach the Lebanon section, we will follow that complicated burial journey.” That gesture makes Lebanon feel anticipated rather than disconnected.

Transition. “Allen and Jones created institutions to care for Black Philadelphians when white institutions would not. More than a century later, Martin Lehmann and Eden’s other founders confronted the same fundamental problem on the scale of an entire cemetery.”

02 Lehmann

6–8 minutes. Chronological span 1859–1924. Central theme: building and administering Eden. On a three-stop route this material is delivered in the introduction; on a four-stop route it is its own stop.

Plot name. The Lehmann section is named for Martin J. Lehmann (1859–1924), a cigar maker who served as treasurer of the Eden Cemetery Company. Lehmann was one of Eden’s five charter members, whom Eden identifies collectively as its founders.

Founder	Office
John C. Asbury	President
Charles W. Jones	Vice president
Daniel W. Parvis	Vice president
Jerome Bacon	Secretary
Martin J. Lehmann	Treasurer

Interpretation. Lehmann should not be presented merely as a person for whom a plot was named. He represents the financial and administrative work required to create a Black-controlled cemetery:

obtaining a charter; acquiring land; defending the cemetery legally; selling and recording plots; arranging burials and transfers; and sustaining the cemetery as an institution.

Research note. The National Register nomination confirms that the section was named for Lehmann but does not establish its exact naming date. It classifies Lehmann as a “newer” section and indicates that it was being used substantially by 1958. It also cautions that a section’s naming may have occurred after burials began there.

03 Lebanon

15–20 minutes. Central themes: cemetery displacement, reinterment, civil-rights networks, Black control over burial. Principal nodes: James Forten and William Still. Optional clusters: Absalom Jones; Catto and LeCount; the Still-Anderson family; Black medicine.

First, gather and orient the group. *[Position the group where visitors can see the Lebanon sign and as much of the section as possible. Allow everyone to settle before beginning.]* We are now standing at the Lebanon section, one of the most historically important sections at Eden. Lebanon is not named for a famous individual. It preserves the name of an entire Black cemetery that no longer exists. *[Pause and gesture across the section.]* The people buried here did not all arrive in the same way. Some were removed from Lebanon Cemetery in Philadelphia and transferred here in 1903. Others were buried directly at Eden years or decades later. That distinction, between a transferred ancestor and a later Eden burial, will help us understand this section.

Second, how Lebanon received its name. Lebanon Cemetery was chartered in Philadelphia on January 24, 1849. It stood near what is now Nineteenth Street and Snyder Avenue in South Philadelphia. It was a nonsectarian cemetery created for African Americans who were excluded from many white cemeteries. Its establishment represented progress: Black Philadelphians had secured a dedicated place in which members of their community could be buried. But ownership and designation did not guarantee permanent protection.

In 1882, newspapers exposed an organized body-snatching operation at Lebanon. Bodies had been removed from graves and sold to Jefferson Medical College for anatomical study. In 1899, Philadelphia condemned Lebanon Cemetery. As the city expanded, the land occupied by the cemetery became valuable for other uses. When Eden opened, thousands of remains were removed from Lebanon and brought here. By 1903, the original cemetery had closed.

The name “Lebanon” does more than identify this section. It preserves the name of a Black place that was erased from Philadelphia’s physical

Third, Absalom Jones: a burial journey spanning four places. *[Gesture back toward the Richard Allen section.]* At the Richard Allen section, we discussed the Free African Society, which Richard Allen, Absalom Jones, and others established in 1787. Absalom Jones died on February 13, 1818.

Remains now elsewhere. He was first buried in the churchyard of the African Episcopal Church of St. Thomas, the church he helped establish with assistance from James Forten and other members of Philadelphia's Black community. When that church moved, Jones's remains were transferred to Lebanon Cemetery. When Lebanon closed, his remains were transferred again, from Lebanon to Eden. In 1991, Jones's remains were removed from Eden and returned to the African Episcopal Church of St. Thomas. Jones's journey demonstrates that reinterment was not always a single event. Some Black remains traveled through several burial landscapes as churches moved, cemeteries closed, and cities changed.

Fourth, James Forten: the central nineteenth-century node. Another person connecting Jones to this section is James Forten. James Forten died on March 4, 1842.

Transferred. Forten was originally buried at the African Episcopal Church of St. Thomas at Fifth and Adelphi Streets. His remains were subsequently moved to Lebanon Cemetery and eventually transferred here to Eden. *[Gesture toward Forten's marker or in its general direction.]* Forten had been born in Philadelphia in 1766. As a young man, he served aboard an American privateer during the Revolutionary War. He later became a successful sailmaker, employer, abolitionist, and supporter of Black education. But Forten is especially valuable to this tour because he connects several generations and several sections of Eden.

- **Connection backward: Absalom Jones.** Forten helped Absalom Jones establish the African Episcopal Church of St. Thomas in 1794. He also supported schools for Black children and adults. Religious independence, education, mutual aid, and burial were not separate projects. They were different parts of building an independent Black community.
- **Connection forward: William Whipper at Olive.** *[Gesture toward Olive if visible; otherwise in the direction the tour will travel.]* Later, when we reach the Olive section, we will meet William Whipper. Forten and Whipper participated in the American Moral Reform Society, an organization concerned with abolition, education, temperance, economic advancement, and collective responsibility. Forten died in 1842 and Whipper in 1876. They belonged to overlapping generations: Forten helped create institutions that Whipper's generation entered, expanded, and sometimes challenged.
- **Connection within Lebanon: James J. G. Bias.** James Joshua Gould Bias died on July 15, 1860. **Transferred.** Bias was originally buried at Lebanon Cemetery and was transferred to Eden when the cemetery was displaced. Bias was a physician, minister, abolitionist, Vigilance Committee leader, and

participant in the Colored Conventions movement. He also connects Forten's generation to William Whipper and Stephen Smith. Convention records place these men within the same larger movement of Black political organization.

[Pause and look across the section.] **One way to remember this network.** Jones helped build religious independence. Forten connected religious, educational, and abolitionist work. Bias joined medicine to abolition and political organizing. Whipper and Smith connected reform to business and economic power.

Fifth, Octavius Catto: murder, voting, and reinterment. *[Shift the group's attention or move a few steps if Catto's location can be indicated.]* Octavius Valentine Catto died on October 10, 1871.

Transferred. He was originally buried at Lebanon Cemetery. His remains were transferred to Eden on May 14, 1903. Catto was only thirty-two when he was murdered during election-day racial violence in Philadelphia. His work brought together several cultural and political worlds: education, voting rights, Black military service, streetcar desegregation, baseball, and public commemoration.

- **Connection to William Still.** Catto worked within the same Philadelphia civil-rights network as William Still. Both participated in the campaign to desegregate the city's streetcars.
- **Connection to Caroline LeCount.** Catto was engaged to educator and activist Caroline LeCount. LeCount died on January 24, 1923. **Direct Eden burial.** Unlike Catto, LeCount was not transferred here with Lebanon Cemetery. She died twenty years after the transfer and was buried directly at Eden in the section where Catto had been reinterred. This gives us one of the clearest examples of the distinction we are following. Catto was moved here because Lebanon Cemetery was closed. LeCount was later buried here after Lebanon had become an Eden section. Their presence in the same section reunites two connected lives, but their bodies arrived through different historical processes.
- **Optional memory cue.** Catto represents displacement. LeCount represents return, or reunion.

Sixth, William Still: the generational bridge. William Still died on July 14, 1902, about one month before Celestine Cromwell's burial opened Eden.

Sequence unconfirmed. Still is recorded as buried at Eden, but the precise sequence between his death and interment should be confirmed in Eden's first interment register before the guide states that Eden was unquestionably his first burial location. **Until the record is checked, do not label Still as transferred or as a direct burial in the spoken tour. Say only that he is buried here.**

Still was an abolitionist, Underground Railroad organizer, businessman, writer, and historian. His 1872 book, *The Underground Rail Road*, preserved accounts of hundreds of freedom seekers and the people who assisted them. Still connects multiple sections of the tour.

- **Backward to James Forten.** Still belonged to a later generation of Philadelphia abolitionists. Forten's generation built many of the religious, educational, and reform institutions through which Still's generation worked.
- **To John Brown, back or forward depending on route.** Still worked with Frances Ellen Watkins Harper in Philadelphia's abolitionist community. Harper is buried in the John Brown section.
- **To Catto and LeCount.** Still, Catto, and LeCount participated in the struggle to desegregate Philadelphia streetcars.
- **To the Still-Anderson family.** Still also connects abolition to the emergence of Black-controlled medical and social-service institutions. His daughter, Caroline Still Anderson, died on June 1, 1919. **Direct Eden burial.** She was buried directly at Eden in the Lebanon section. Caroline was a physician and educator. Her husband, Matthew Anderson, was a Presbyterian minister and the founder of Berean Presbyterian Church. *[Gesture back toward Celestine.]* Matthew Anderson is buried in Celestine. Together, Caroline and Matthew developed medical, educational, religious, and social-service programs through Berean Presbyterian Church.

The Still-Anderson family connects two plots and two generations. William Still represents abolition and the Underground Railroad. Caroline Still Anderson represents medicine and education. Matthew Anderson represents religion and community institution-building.

Optional deep dive: the Black medical network. *[Use only if approximately four or more minutes remain.]* The Lebanon section also contains an extraordinary cluster of Black medical and public-health history.

- **Caroline Still Anderson** died on June 1, 1919. She was one of the earliest Black women physicians in Philadelphia.
- **Nathan Francis Mossell** died on October 27, 1946. **Direct Eden burial.** He was buried at Eden long after the Lebanon transfer. Mossell became the first Black graduate of the University of Pennsylvania's medical school and founded Frederick Douglass Memorial Hospital. The hospital offered medical care to Black patients while creating professional opportunities for Black physicians and nurses excluded from many white institutions.
- **Gertrude Bustill Mossell** died on January 21, 1948. **Direct Eden burial.** She was buried directly at Eden beside the later generations associated with this section. She was a journalist, author, educator, suffragist, and fundraiser, and helped generate support for the hospital her husband founded. Together, the Mossells show that institution-building required more than a physician. It required writing, fundraising, public persuasion, women's organizing, and community trust.
- **Connection back to Celestine.** Rebecca J. Cole, buried in Celestine, also belonged to Philadelphia's pioneering generation of Black women physicians. The available evidence establishes a shared professional world, but not every proposed personal relationship among Cole, Anderson, and Mossell

has yet been confirmed. **Describe them as part of an overlapping medical network, not automatically as close friends or collaborators.**

Optional deep dive: Laura Wheeler Waring. Laura Wheeler Waring died on February 3, 1948. **Direct Eden burial.** She was a later direct burial at Eden, not a person transferred from the original Lebanon Cemetery. Waring was a painter and educator known especially for her portraits of prominent Black Americans. She gives the guide two connections. *[Gesture toward Olive.]* Jessie Redmon Fauset, whom we will meet at Olive, was Waring’s friend and traveling companion. They traveled together in Europe and North Africa. *[Gesture back toward Celestine.]* Waring also painted Marian Anderson, who is buried in Celestine. Waring therefore connects three sections: Waring at Lebanon, Fauset at Olive, Anderson at Celestine.

Lebanon summary. *[Bring the group’s attention back to the whole plot.]* Lebanon contains several different kinds of burial history. Absalom Jones’s remains passed through this section and were later returned to St. Thomas. James Forten, James Bias, and Octavius Catto were transferred after earlier burial grounds closed. Caroline LeCount, Caroline Still Anderson, the Mossells, and Laura Wheeler Waring were buried at Eden later, after Lebanon had become one of its established sections. The plot therefore represents both displacement and continuity. The dead moved here from a place that disappeared. Later generations then chose, or were given, burial among them.

Transition out of Lebanon. “Lebanon preserves the name of a lost Black cemetery. Our next stop shows another way a plot name can communicate memory: it could express allegiance to a historical figure and the unfinished struggle that figure represented.” *[Move toward John Brown.]*

04 John Brown

Main node: Frances Ellen Watkins Harper. Chronological anchor: February 22, 1911. **Direct Eden burial.**

Open with the distinction. “John Brown gives this section its name, but he is not buried here.” Then introduce Harper: “Frances Ellen Watkins Harper died on February 22, 1911, and was buried directly at Eden in the John Brown section.”

Why the location matters. Her burial location carried political meaning. Eden explains that Harper regarded Brown as a friend and hero. She also connects backward to William Still at Lebanon through Philadelphia’s abolitionist and Underground Railroad networks.

Optional cluster. The United States Colored Troops, and the use of cemetery space to preserve Civil War memory.



SECTION 3

Technical Architecture

What has been delivered, and how Eden keeps it running with almost no cost and limited technical resources.

Technical Architecture Recommendation

A low-cost, low-maintenance digital foundation for Eden Cemetery

PREPARED BY 1838 BLACK METROPOLIS · RECLAIM. REWRITE. & RESTORE.

The problem we are solving

Eden Cemetery carries extraordinary historical weight — documented Underground Railroad connections and roughly 93,000 burials across some 17,000 lots — including United States Colored Troops veterans and generations of Philadelphia's Black community. But the organization is operating under real financial strain.

A digital plan for Eden cannot be judged by how impressive it is. It has to be judged by one question: **can Eden keep it running with almost no money and almost no dedicated technical staff?** Every recommendation below is built around that constraint. The goal is a digital presence that is dignified, useful, and — most importantly — *sustainable* without ongoing cost or technical upkeep.

The core principle is a division of labor between two kinds of digital space:

A powerful, immersive, informative website that is low cost and low maintenance — and social interaction and events that leverage existing free social tools.

Keep the permanent, reference material on a website that requires no maintenance. Put everything that changes — events, announcements, conversation, partnerships — on free tools Eden's audience already uses. Never pay to update something you could update for free.

01 A self-contained website Eden owns outright

We have built Eden a new website that is rich and interactive for the people who visit it, yet self-contained and maintenance-free for the organization that runs it. Those two things sound like they

should be in tension — they aren't, and that distinction is the heart of this recommendation.

Immersive for the visitor. This is not a plain brochure page. Visitors will explore a **clickable map** of the grounds, **search and filter the notables** buried at Eden, follow the self-guided **walking tours**, and move through the history in interactive ways. It should feel useful, modern, and alive — a real destination, not a placeholder.

Self-contained for Eden. All of that interactivity happens in the visitor's browser. Behind the scenes, the site is a self-contained package that simply sits on Eden's existing web address and runs on its own. There is no content management system to log into, nothing to patch, and no monthly software bill. Once it is in place, it can keep working for years without anyone editing it.

What "self-contained" really means — and why it beats Squarespace or Wix. On a platform like Squarespace or Wix, every change means someone has to know how to log into that platform and edit the site — and Eden keeps paying the monthly fee for the privilege. We recommend the opposite: build everything Eden needs into the site now, then **get off Squarespace entirely**. No subscription, no login, no one on the hook to maintain it. The site holds Eden over comfortably for the next year — long enough to stop paying for a platform it can't currently staff.

Live content without touching the website. The one thing that genuinely changes over time is events — and those don't need a website edit at all. Eden can run its events calendar on Facebook and have it *feed into* the website automatically. The live content updates itself from somewhere else; the website never has to be opened up and edited to stay current.

The one recurring cost. Realistically, the only ongoing expense is the annual web hosting / domain fee Eden likely already pays. There is no separate software subscription layered on top.

What the website must make obvious. Because the site is a reference point rather than a conversation, its most important job — beyond the history and maps — is to tell every visitor, clearly and immediately, **how to reach Eden and how to get involved**. A visitor should never have to hunt for how to contact the organization, how to donate, or where the community is active. Wherever possible, that path should point outward to Facebook, where Eden's living presence will be.

02 Facebook as Eden's living hub

Everything that *does* change belongs on Facebook, not the website. When Eden wants to promote an event, share news, or celebrate a discovery from the archives, the instinct is to "add it to the website." We recommend resisting that instinct every time. **Updating a website costs time and often money. Posting on Facebook is free and takes minutes.**

Facebook is the right home for Eden's active presence for several concrete reasons:

- **The audience is already there.** Eden's core community — descendants, local residents, history and genealogy enthusiasts — is disproportionately active on Facebook. Meeting them where they already are is far more effective than asking them to visit a website.
- **Events are built in and free.** Facebook's Events feature handles invitations, reminders, RSVPs, and sharing at no cost. This is the direct answer whenever Eden asks about putting events "on the site."
- **It is where partnerships form.** As the brand marketing plan identifies organizations and allies for Eden to connect with, most of that relationship-building — tagging, sharing, co-promoting — happens naturally in social spaces, not on a static website.
- **It is a two-way channel.** People can message, comment, and respond. The website tells people how to reach Eden; Facebook is one of the places they actually do.

Connecting the two. Events created in Facebook can be surfaced on the website by pulling them over — so the website can *display* Eden's upcoming events without anyone ever hand-editing the site. Facebook remains the single place Eden updates; the website simply reflects it. This keeps the "never touch the website" principle intact while still letting visitors see what's happening.

03 One post, two platforms — Instagram via Meta

Because Facebook and Instagram are both owned by Meta, they are connected. Eden can **cross-post from Facebook to Instagram automatically**, reaching a younger and more visual audience without any extra work.

This matters for a resource-strapped organization: the walking-tour photography and archival images we are developing become content that serves *both* platforms from a single post. There is no separate Instagram workflow to staff — it is a setting, not a second job. Instagram is a secondary channel, not a priority: simply switch cross-posting on so Eden gets the added reach for free, while keeping all real activity centered on Facebook.

04 One volunteer role: social media

The single most valuable thing Eden can add to this system is **one person who owns social media — and only social media**.

This does not need to be a paid staff member. We recommend Eden recruit a **dedicated social media volunteer** whose entire, well-defined job is to keep Facebook active: post events, share news, respond

to messages and comments, and nurture the partnership connections the brand plan sets up. Narrow scope is the point. "Manage all of Eden's digital everything" is a job no volunteer will sustain. "Post to Facebook and answer messages" is a job someone can actually hold.

This role is what makes the whole architecture work, and it is deliberately the *only* ongoing human commitment the system requires. The website needs no one. Facebook needs one focused volunteer.

05 Repurpose the contract's 50 hours to cover the site this year

Eden's current contract with 1838 includes **50 hours of writing support**. Because the brand marketing plan moves Eden's ongoing communication onto Facebook, that writing time is no longer where the value is. We propose **repurposing those 50 hours into website support** for the coming year.

Practically, this means Eden does not have to learn to edit the site or hire anyone to do it. Whenever a small change is needed — a correction, a new photo, a tweak to the tours or notables — **1838 makes it directly**, drawn from the 50 hours already in the contract. There is no new cost, and no new burden on Eden. The hours are already budgeted; we are simply pointing them at the more useful task.

This is deliberately scoped to *small* changes. It is not open-ended redevelopment — it is enough hands-on support to keep the site accurate and current while Eden spends this year focused on what matters most: **brand awareness and getting people involved with Eden**. And it carries Eden cleanly to the point where longer-term help arrives.

06 A clear path to Penn Praxis next year

Within roughly a year, Eden is expected to receive support from **Penn Praxis** at the University of Pennsylvania. This architecture is designed to hand off to those students cleanly.

Because the website is a self-contained package, it is an ideal project for student developers to extend when that help arrives — adding features, deepening the maps, or building richer ways to explore the burial records. Nothing in the current setup locks Eden in or has to be undone first.

The sequencing is deliberate: **stand up the sustainable system now, let 1838 keep it current through the 50 hours this year, and let Penn Praxis build on it next year**. Eden gets a working, dignified presence immediately, at almost no cost, and a natural on-ramp for skilled help exactly when the budget and the partnership are ready for it — rather than paying for development it can't currently afford.

What this costs Eden

Component	Ongoing cost	Who maintains it
Self-contained website (clickable map, notables search, walking tours)	Annual hosting / domain fee only	No one — it just runs
Facebook page & events	Free	One social media volunteer
Instagram (cross-posted from Facebook)	Free	Automatic — no extra work
Small site changes this year	No new cost — covered by contract	1838, via repurposed 50 hours
Future development	Deferred	Penn Praxis, in ~1 year

The entire recurring financial commitment is the web hosting fee Eden likely already pays. Everything else is free technology Eden's audience is already using.

The shift, in one sentence

Stop treating the website as the place where Eden happens. Let the website be the immersive, self-running front door — beautiful, interactive, and maintenance-free — and let Facebook be the living room where the community gathers, events are announced, and partnerships grow. It costs almost nothing, it meets Eden's people where they already are, and it is built to survive the organization's current constraints rather than add to them.